

**Horizon as Deep Time: Hiroshi Sugimoto's Seascapes, Theaters, and an East Asian Method
of Reading Temporal Change**

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Advanced Project: The Futural Image

The medium of photography has long been theorized through its capacity for temporal capture, functioning primarily as an optical apparatus designed to arrest a momentary slice of reality and preserve it against the relentless flow of time. However, this project performs a dual critical function: first, it rigorously analyzes how the contemporary Japanese artist Hiroshi Sugimoto makes time visible through his expansive photographic practice; second, by utilizing Sugimoto's durational strategies, it fundamentally rethinks how time is structurally organized, mobilized, and perceived within the photographic image itself.

The core argument of this paper unfolds across four distinct, interwoven layers of analysis. First, Sugimoto's work systematically shatters the classical understanding of photography as the mere capture of a fleeting, decisive "instant." Second, he makes time visible not through narrative progression, causal events, or obvious, indexical changes, but rather as an accumulated, luminous surface and a slow, continuous state of structural transformation. Third, this unique durational approach results in a profound manifestation of "layered time": a condition where multiple temporal scales, ranging from intimate personal memory to the vastness of planetary deep time, coexist simultaneously within a single, highly minimal visual structure. Finally, and most crucially, this paper argues that traditional, linear historical narratives are fundamentally inadequate for interpreting this kind of image. To truly comprehend this temporal form, we require a different methodological reading—one drawn directly from East Asian philosophy. Specifically, the *Yijing* (Book of Changes) and François Jullien's concept of "silent transformations" provide the necessary epistemological framework, shifting our analytical focus toward structural configurations, propensity (*shi*), gradual accumulation, and threshold

crossings.¹

By unpacking these four layers through close visual and theoretical analyses of Sugimoto's *Theaters* and *Seascapes* series, this research reorients the conceptual trajectory of the "futural image." Within contemporary visual and queer theory, the "futural image" is often defined through Lee Edelman's concept of "reproductive futurism", a horizon of "Imaginary fullness" that attempts to fix identity and secure the prevailing social order by rigidly anticipating, controlling, and managing what comes next. Film theorist William Brown categorizes such anticipatory media under a "control regime," wherein the future is restricted in order to paralyze the passage of pure time and maintain the ideological stability of the present. Sugimoto's durational photography, conversely, aligns much closer to what Brown terms a "synchronistic image", one that captures the chaotic, unmanageable whole of pure potential. This project does not merely apply theoretical frameworks to Sugimoto's work; rather, it mobilizes these frameworks to articulate a mode of temporality that emerges from the images themselves—one defined by accumulation, structural configuration, and imperceptible planetary transformation.

Within the dominant traditions of Western visual culture and photographic theory, photography is fundamentally understood as a medium designed to arrest a momentary slice of reality. Tracing back to Henri Cartier-Bresson's famously championed "decisive moment," the photographic image typically captures a specific, unrepeatable action, a fleeting facial expression, or a dramatic, causal scene. In this classical ontology, the camera acts as a guillotine

¹ Richard John Lynn, trans., *The Classic of Changes: A New Translation of the I Ching as Interpreted by Wang Bi* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 370–371; François Jullien, *The Silent Transformations*, trans. Krzysztof Fijalkowski and Michael Richardson (Kolkata: Seagull Books, 2011), 18–20.

of duration, effectively cutting a distinct, isolated block out of the flowing river of time and fixing it permanently in chemical silver or digital code. The photograph is lauded precisely for its ability to stop time, to cheat entropy, and to provide an objective, indexical record of an event that has irrevocably passed. Sugimoto's comprehensive, decades-long project systematically challenges and radically breaks this classical ontology.

Rather than merely extending photographic duration for aesthetic effect, Sugimoto's work repositions photography within what theorist Joanna Zylińska describes as a "nonhuman temporality," where images no longer register discrete human events but instead participate in broader, geological material processes that vastly exceed human perception and lifespan.² As Zylińska notes in her foundational text *Nonhuman Photography*, the medium always involves a "cut" that temporarily stabilizes the world into discernible entities out of the chaotic, unceasing flow of duration.³ However, in Sugimoto's durational practice, this "cut" does not isolate a rapid, singular moment. Instead, his camera accumulates an extended, massive duration, transforming photography from an act of rapid extraction into an apparatus of profound temporal aggregation.

In his *Theaters* series, initiated in the late 1970s upon his arrival in the United States, Sugimoto deploys a methodology that is conceptually elegant but technically demanding. He brings a large-format 8x10 camera into various classic American movie palaces and drive-in theaters, opens the shutter at the exact moment the feature film begins, and leaves it open for the entire duration of the projection.⁴

Similarly, in his globally recognized *Seascapes* series (begun in 1980), Sugimoto entirely

² Joanna Zylińska, *Nonhuman Photography* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2017), 104.

³ Zylińska, *Nonhuman Photography*, 5.

⁴ Hiroshi Sugimoto, *Hiroshi Sugimoto: Time Machine* (Ostfildern: Hatje Cantz, 2023), 60.

avoids capturing dramatic, decisive moments in nature. Photographing bodies of water around the globe—from the Caribbean Sea to the Arctic Ocean. By deliberately evacuating the instantaneous, narrative event from the photographic frame, Sugimoto forces the viewer out of the rapid, frantic tempo of human action and immerses them in the slow, stabilizing accumulation of pure duration. The massive geological and cosmic scales that operate far beyond the narrow stretch of human culture.⁵ In both the *Theaters* and *Seascapes* series, the 8x10 camera ceases to be a tool for capturing a human instant and instead becomes a cosmological apparatus for accumulating deep, nonhuman time.

If Sugimoto is not capturing an instant or documenting a specific historical event, how does time actually become visible in his work? In standard Western visual logic, time is most easily and commonly understood as “what happens”, a linear, event-driven, narrative sequence. Time is rendered legible through causation: Event A causes Event B, which logically leads to Event C.

Mary Ann Doane’s foundational work, *The Emergence of Cinematic Time: Modernity, Contingency, the Archive*, brilliantly articulates how classical film and its associated technological apparatus were designed specifically to archive this kind of linear contingency. Doane demonstrates that cinematic time depends on the rapid production of continuity from entirely discontinuous frames (the 24-frames-per-second illusion), generating what she calls a “simulacrum of time” grounded in the psychological illusion of temporal plenitude and linear flow.⁶ Cinema emerged at the turn of the twentieth century as a way to manage, rationalize, and

⁵ Zylinska, *Nonhuman Photography*, 104.

⁶ Mary Ann Doane, *The Emergence of Cinematic Time: Modernity, Contingency, the Archive* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002), 172.

archive the chaotic, fleeting events of modernity.

Sugimoto's *Theaters* series radically inverts this logic and subverts the archival ambition of cinema by turning the apparatus inward upon itself. Rather than producing continuity from discrete instants to tell a story, his extremely long-exposure technique collapses an entire feature film into a single, blindingly overexposed surface.⁷ The viewer cannot see the plot of the film, the sequence of narrative events, the cuts, or the movements of the actors, because the sheer, overwhelming accumulation of visual narrative data has obliterated itself through light saturation. The moving image is entirely exhausted. If cinema traditionally attempts to reconstruct movement and time from immobilities (still frames), Sugimoto demonstrates that excessive accumulation leads not to movement, but to profound visual collapse and spatial vacancy.

As Stefano Baschiera notes in his crucial analysis of this series, *The Cinematic Dispositif and Its Ghost: Sugimoto's Theaters*, Sugimoto's work can be understood as capturing a "film in a single frame," effectively compressing hundreds of thousands of individual cinematic images into a single photographic surface.⁸ However, rather than preserving cinematic time, this radical compression produces what might be described as an "exhausted image", an image in which duration is no longer narratable, linear, or decipherable, but is only perceptible as a luminous, glowing residue. What is made visible is not a story, but the physical, chemical sedimentation of a continuous duration. The screen becomes a pure void of white light, an "archive of duration" that compels viewers to interrogate the temporal and spatial foundations of the cinematic

⁷ Sugimoto, *Time Machine*, 62.

⁸ Stefano Baschiera, "The Cinematic Dispositif and Its Ghost: Sugimoto's Theaters," in *Theorizing Film Through Contemporary Art: Expanding Cinema*, ed. Jill Murphy and Laura Rascaroli (Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2020), 195.

experience itself.⁹

In the *Seascapes* series, time is similarly divorced from narrative progression. History and duration are made visible not through sequential human actions, but through incredibly subtle, almost imperceptible micro-variations. The differences between these images are registered through atmospheric density, tonal gradation, light, and the blur at the horizon rather than through events or landmarks.¹⁰ Sugimoto meticulously renders time visible as a structural condition and a slow-shifting, ambient state, proving with exacting formal rigor that time can be profoundly materialized in visual media without relying on the crutch of a human story.

This demanding method of temporal compression and visual accumulation does not yield a singular, flat, or monolithic temporality. Instead, it produces what contemporary theorists term “layered time” the simultaneous manifestation of coexisting, polyrhythmic temporalities that interact with and “haunt” a single space simultaneously. This coexistence resembles Deleuze’s crystal-image.”

The *Seascapes* are perhaps the ultimate vessels for this layered temporality. When looking at the rigorously, mathematically bisected horizon line that characterizes every photograph in the series, the viewer is not looking at a single moment in time, but is rather simultaneously encountering three distinct temporal strata:

1. **Personal Time:** Sugimoto has stated that the series originated from his own childhood memories of viewing the ocean, an observation that immediately triggers the viewer's own phenomenological memory and intimate sensory experiences of the sea.¹¹

⁹ Baschiera, "The Cinematic Dispositif and Its Ghost," 195.

¹⁰ Sugimoto, *Time Machine*, 110.

¹¹ Sugimoto, *Time Machine*, 112.

2. **Historical Time:** The image inevitably evokes the entire span of recorded human maritime history, navigation, global trade, and colonial expansion across the oceans.
3. **Deep Time (Chronos):** The vast geological continuum, dating back billions of years. By choosing the ocean—a topography that remains visually constant despite the violent tectonic shifting of the earth's landmasses—Sugimoto explicitly frames the sea as a prehistoric view.¹² It is a deep-time platform that accesses an origin point long before human history began, allowing the contemporary viewer to share a visual horizon with the earliest forms of consciousness.

The *Theaters* series exhibits a similarly dense stratification of layered time. A single photograph from this series holds the two-to-three-hour narrative duration of the projected Hollywood film, the historical age and ornate architectural decay of the physical 1920s movie palace, the technical exposure time of the 8x10 photographic apparatus itself, and the broader cultural timeline of twentieth-century cinematic exhibition and its eventual obsolescence. This layering is made explicitly clear in Sugimoto's later continuation of the project, *Abandoned Theaters*, where he projects films into ruined, decaying cinemas. As Sugimoto notes regarding these ruins, “People misunderstand that the end is not coming. It has already begun”.¹³ Rather than portraying one specific, fleeting “feeling” of time, Sugimoto’s minimal, highly formal compositions act as structural containers where entirely different temporal scales are folded together and forced to coexist in structural tension.

This dense stratification of time brings us to the methodological crux of the paper. To

¹² Sugimoto, *Time Machine*, 114.

¹³ Baschiera, "The Cinematic Dispositif and Its Ghost," 201.

truly understand the complex temporal structures Sugimoto builds, we must recognize the severe limitations of our standard Western analytical tools. Traditional, linear historical frameworks—which rely on the identification of loud events, obvious chronological sequences, narrative climaxes, and traditional historical tableaux, immediately encounter analytical dead ends when faced with Sugimoto's work. His images lack clear events, and they actively resist linear chronological mapping. Therefore, a radically different hermeneutic lens is required.

To bridge this gap, this project proposes an East Asian philosophical framework. Sugimoto himself, having moved to California in the 1970s, was profoundly influenced by Eastern philosophy, Zen Buddhism, and Japanese classics, recognizing that these traditions offered a different epistemology of time and space. By utilizing the *Yijing* (Book of Changes) and François Jullien's contemporary theories of change, we gain the exact vocabulary needed to articulate time not as a line, but as structure, propensity, and gradual, continuous variation.

In the *Yijing* (particularly as interpreted by Wang Bi and translated by Richard John Lynn), time is not conceptualized as a straight arrow moving inexorably forward from past to future. Rather, it is understood as a continuous series of positional stages and configurations defined by relational positions. Each of the sixty-four hexagrams in the *Yijing* represents a highly specific situational structure and a dynamic state of tension, rather than a discrete moment in a sequential timeline.¹⁴ This epistemological framework allows us to read Sugimoto's images not as representations of temporal flow, but as complex configurations of temporal relations, where different durations (human, technological, geological) are held in perfect structural tension.

Central to this reading is the East Asian aesthetic and philosophical concept of *shi*. Often

¹⁴ Lynn, *The Classic of Changes*, 371.

translated as “organizational propensity” or the interactive force of situational momentum, *shi* refers to the latent energy or inevitable momentum derived from the specific alignment of forces in a given circumstance. It is the power that is developing quietly before manifesting into identifiable, naming outcomes.

Applying the concept of *shi* to the *Theaters* series radically alters our understanding of the blank, overexposed cinema screen. To the Western eye, the glowing white rectangle might appear as an “empty” void, an erasure or a lack of image. However, viewed through the lens of *shi*, it is the ultimate visual manifestation of absolute fullness. It is a surface overflowing with the latent energy and accumulated propensity of an entire film's duration, hovering at a threshold of maximum tension. The architectural details of the theater that surround the screen—the ornate plasterwork, the empty seats—serve as the physical configuration that contains and directs this tremendous situational momentum.

This structural reading is deeply reinforced and expanded by the contemporary French philosopher François Jullien’s concept of “silent transformations.” In his book *The Silent Transformations*, Jullien observes that classical Greek ontology has historically propelled Western thought into what he calls the “vertigo of the event”.¹⁵ Western philosophy and historiography are overwhelmingly fixated on determined forms, loud ruptures, heroic actions, and definitive beginnings and ends. Because of this foundational bias, Western thought consistently fails to notice the profound effects of cumulative, imperceptible changes over time. East Asian philosophy, however, recognizes that the most fundamental and powerful changes, aging, the shifting of the seasons, the erosion of mountains, global warming, are “silent

¹⁵ Jullien, *The Silent Transformations*, 18.

transformations”. They do not happen with a sudden rupture or a cinematic explosion; they happen continuously, globally, and without fanfare, only becoming apparent to human perception once a critical threshold is irrevocably crossed. As Jullien argues, true transformation unfolds as a continuous process that remains “too continuous... to be discerned”.¹⁶

This insight is absolutely crucial for understanding the temporal mechanics of Sugimoto’s *Seascapes*. In these photographs, change is not visible as an event. There is no action to arrest. Instead, time and change accumulate through infinite micro-variations in light, atmospheric pressure, and the tonal density of the water. What becomes visible in Sugimoto’s images is therefore not the act of transformation itself, but its accumulated, structural effect. This aligns precisely with Jullien’s claim that silent transformation can only be perceived retrospectively. By strictly eschewing the dramatic, decisive event, Sugimoto aligns his camera with the slow, inexorable logic of silent transformation. His work demands a reading method that values the invisible accumulation of atmospheric and geological shifts over the loud, anthropocentric declarations of linear history.

The realization of this non-linear, structural framework relies heavily not just on the image itself, but on the phenomenological experience of the viewer in the gallery space. As Salvador Jiménez-Donaire Martínez argues in his scholarship on Sugimoto’s blank images, Sugimoto’s durational strategies dictate a highly specific, enforced viewing pace. They produce an “image-time” that aggressively resists the immediacy of modern media consumption and demands prolonged, disciplined perceptual engagement.¹⁷

¹⁶ Jullien, *The Silent Transformations*, 31.

¹⁷ Salvador Jiménez-Donaire Martínez, “Una Imagen en Blanco. Percepción y Tiempo en la Fotografía de Hiroshi Sugimoto,” *BRAC: Barcelona Research Art Creation* 11, no. 1 (2023): 150.

When confronting a seemingly “empty” *Seascape* or a blank, glowing *Theater* screen, the viewer is initially deprived of all obvious narrative data. The eye cannot quickly scan the frame for a human face, a recognizable action, or a dramatic “event” to easily consume and categorize. This initial deprivation forces a physical and cognitive slowdown. This enforced slowness is not merely an aesthetic byproduct; it is a vital structural component of the work. It conditions the viewer’s capacity to perceive temporal accumulation and subtle transformation.

The viewer must settle into a state of meditative endurance, spending extended time with the physical print. Only through this durational viewing do the micro-variations in the silver gelatin, the layered time of the horizon, and the intense *shi* of the image slowly begin to reveal themselves. This perceptual pacing perfectly mimics the silent transformations depicted within the frame; meaning does not arrive instantly as a sudden revelation, but rather accumulates gradually, layer upon layer, mirroring the slow accretion of deep time itself.

We are currently living in the age of the Anthropocene—a proposed geological epoch defined by the undeniable, massive impact of human industrial activity on the global climate and the earth's lithosphere. In the Anthropocene, the boundaries separating short-term human narrative time from the vast, previously indifferent scale of geological deep time have violently collapsed. The rapid extraction and combustion of fossil fuels (which are quite literally millions of years of deep time compressed into modern, consumable energy) is radically and quickly altering the planetary structure.

Joanna Zylińska argues that in this era, both the fossil and the photograph materialize the movements of deep time, as both are fundamentally dependent on the extraction of resources

(silver, minerals, fossil fuels) from the earth's crust.¹⁸ By layering these vast temporalities within his minimal frames, Sugimoto subtly but devastatingly critiques the anthropocentric hubris of the Western 'conservation ideal.'

This theme is explored most explicitly in another of his major photographic series, *Dioramas*, where he photographs the elaborate taxidermy animal displays inside natural history museums.¹⁹ By photographing these meticulously staged, artificial scenes with the same large-format precision he applies to the actual ocean, Sugimoto draws attention to human attempts to freeze biological time and conquer death. However, human attempts to freeze time, whether through the taxidermy of the museum archive, the narrative closure of cinema, or even the classical documentary photograph, are ultimately fragile, temporary, and doomed to fail.

When viewed as a holistic project, Sugimoto's *Abandoned Theaters*—decaying under the slow, silent weight of architectural entropy—and the eternal, indifferent, and austere horizon of his *Seascapes*, serve as a profound reminder of our precarious position. They remind us that all human narrative time, all of our technological triumphs, and all of our architectural monuments will eventually be subsumed by the silent, relentless, geological transformations of the planet.

Hiroshi Sugimoto's comprehensive, masterful photographic practice offers much more than a stunning visual meditation on the sea, the cinema, or the museum; it provides a radical, necessary blueprint for reorganizing how time is presented, understood, and perceived in visual media. By completely dismantling the classical photographic instant and evacuating linear narrative sequences from his frames, Sugimoto makes time visible as a physical, luminous

¹⁸ Zylinska, *Nonhuman Photography*, 127.

¹⁹ Sugimoto, *Time Machine*, 30.

surface and a structural, material accumulation. His minimal compositions generate a profound ‘layered time’, where the brief, frantic span of human historical experience is folded seamlessly into the terrifying immensity of the geological continuum.

Most importantly, Sugimoto’s work exposes the severe limitations of Western, linear historical narratives in comprehending the true scale of planetary change. His photography demands a profound methodological shift toward East Asian temporalities. By utilizing the *Yijing*’s focus on relational configuration and situational propensity (*shi*), alongside François Jullien’s concept of ‘silent transformations,’ we are able to understand time and change not as a rapid series of loud, dramatic human events, but as a continuous, quiet, and inexorable accumulation of forces.

In doing so, Sugimoto completely reorients the concept of the ‘futural image’ away from anxious human attempts to predict, manage, and control narrative time. Instead, he points us toward the enduring, primordial horizon. His work reveals that true futurity is not found in the manic acceleration of modern technology or the reproductive futurism of the social order, but is rather inextricably bound to the silent, slow-moving, and indifferent structures of deep time—a time that preceded us, sustains us, and will ultimately outlast us.

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